



The Congress's fortunes have nosedived from **132** seats in 1999 to **65** in the last polls, its vote percentage also slipped from **41%** to **35%**

AWOL: Rahul was too busy with his "Discover India" journey and Sonia mostly stayed away

mandate, which is the most likely scenario—a repeat of the 2004 polls in which the BJP, despite winning 79 seats, more than any other party, failed to form a government. BJP leader B.S. Yeddyurappa, chief minister for a week in November last year, has since been crisscrossing the state and is seen as the most popular leader among the many contenders from several parties for chief ministership. The party has already seen top campaigners like Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi and former Central minister Sushma Swaraj hitting the coastal and central Karnataka poll trail.

The Congress, on the other hand, is going through internal convulsions with the latest being a public tussle between a prominent Muslim and a Lingayat in Davanagere, the state's textile capital. The mess was avoidable, coming as it did after senior Congress leader C.K. Jaffer Sharief publicly protested "poor representation" during ticket distributions. He

was later mollified by party President Sonia Gandhi with a promise of an extended stay in one of the Raj Bhavans.

Muslims form 12 per cent of the electorate and the Congress's fortunes lie with them. Senior Congress leader Veerappa Moily admitted to INDIA TODAY that their votes are crucial in at least 105 seats, almost half the Assembly. With the BJP not counting on votes from the minorities, their ballots are up for grabs among the other major players, the Congress, JD(S), BSP and SP. Muslims in the coastal regions, which account for 21 Assembly seats, are also being wooed by the Congress this time.

The Lingayats, who account for 18 per cent of the state's population and are the dominant group, have thrown their weight with the BJP, especially in north and central Karnataka. The Hyderabad-Karnataka region has been neglected for years, and this is where the Congress is hoping to

make some inroads. Likewise the Vokkaligas, who form around 15 per cent of the population, had backed JD(S) to the hilt because Gowda and sons were seen as their saviours. But now, the majority of the lower social bloc, nearly 35 per cent of the electorate comprising OBCs, STs and SCs, is said to be pitching for the Congress as a reaction to the two main caste groups supporting the JD(S) and the BJP.

However, Congress leaders are quite confused with the late arrival of Sonia for the poll campaign. The Election Commission (EC) has placed several restrictions on carting people from one place to another for public rallies; this is one of the reasons why the party leadership in the state has not been able to chart out Sonia's campaign. On the other hand, regional satraps like S. Bangarappa, the state unit head of Samajwadi Party, continue to create trouble for leaders. The powerful Idiga community leader is taking on Yeddyurappa in